THE VIKINGS

DURING THE LATE 8th and 9th centuries Viking sea warriors from Scandinavia terrorized much of Europe, devastating sites along coasts and up rivers. At first small-scale hit-and-run raids mounted by single war bands, these attacks grew into sustained operations involving hundreds of longships, and led to permanent Viking settlement in France and the British Isles. From around 980 a new wave of Viking expansion, led by warriors such as Olaf Trygvasson, struck in particular at Anglo-Saxon England, which came under the rule of the Danish King Canute from 1017. In Scandinavia the kingdoms of Norway, Denmark, and Sweden were consolidated and their warrior kings, or claimants to their thrones, fought one another repeatedly in shifting alliances. Longships were central to Viking invasions and raids, but actual battles on water were rare. When forces clashed at sea, the style of fighting differed little from a battle on land, with an exchange of missiles followed by close combat with axe, sword, and spear.

THE VIKING WORLD c.793–1050 CE

The Viking raids of the late 8th and early 9th centuries were followed by a period of conquest and settlement, with Vikings settling in Iceland as well as in conquered areas of France, Britain, and Ireland. As the regions ruled by the Vikings grew to become powerful states, wars between rival Viking leaders became increasingly frequent as they quarreled over their inheritance.

KEY

- Area settled by Vikings
- Area of Viking influence
- Viking voyage, trade route, or raid
- Major Viking settlement
- 866 Date of Viking voyage, battle, raid, or settlement
- Viking sea battle
- Viking raid



VIKING ATTACKS ON NORTHERN ENGLAND

RAID ON LINDISFARNE



Date June 793
Forces Vikings: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Lindisfarne Island, off Northumbria

In the 8th century the monastery on Lindisfarne was a famed center of Christian learning. Its remote coastal location showed the security felt by a people unsuspecting of seaborne attack. The Viking raiding party that crossed the North Sea and beached its longships near the monastery in 793 met little or no resistance. According to the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle, the raiders "devastated God's church on Lindisfarne island by looting and slaughter." The Vikings stole the treasures of the church and either killed the monks or carried them off in chains to be sold as slaves. Only a hit-and-run attack by a small war band, the raid was a profound shock to Christian Europe. The scholar Alcuin wrote that "never before has such terror appeared as we have suffered from a pagan race."



Viking leader's helmet
Elaborate bronze helmets contributed to the terrifying spectacle of sudden landings of groups of Viking raiders.

VIKING ATTACKS ON NORTHERN FRANCE

RAID ON PARIS



Date November 885–October 886
Forces Vikings: c.300 longships; Franks: 200 men-at-arms
Losses Unknown

Location Paris

In 885 a vast Viking fleet, led by the chieftain Sigfrid, sailed up the River Seine, bent upon pillaging inland France and Burgundy. The Frankish town of Paris, built on the Ile de la Cité, was joined to each bank of the Seine by bridges, one of wood and one of stone. To the surprise of the Vikings, the handful of Frankish warriors in the town, led by Count Odo, defended the bridges, blocking the raiders' progress up the river. A prolonged siege ensued. The Vikings were determined not to be thwarted by a few Frankish warriors: they used siege engines to bombard the fortifications; they attempted to burn the wooden bridge with fireships; they filled moats with dead bodies. After the timber bridge was destroyed by winter floods, some of the Vikings sailed on to plunder elsewhere. The rest were eventually bought off by the Frankish emperor, Charles the Fat, with 60 pounds of silver.

NORWEGIAN-DANISH WAR

SVOLD



Date September 1000
Forces Norwegians: 11 ships; Coalition: c.70 ships
Losses Norwegians: 11 ships; Coalition: unknown

Location Baltic Sea

Olaf Trygvasson, king of Norway, was opposed by a coalition of Danish king Svein Forkbeard, Swedish king Olaf Eiriksson, and the Earl of Lade, Eirik Hakonarson, a pretender to the Norwegian throne. Olaf was sailing home from Wendland when his small fleet was intercepted by a far superior coalition force. The battle that followed is best described by Icelandic chronicler Sonni Sturluson in his sagas of the Norwegian kings, the *Heimskringla*.

King Olaf was traveling on board *Long Serpent*, a ship 165 ft (50 m) long, powered by 70 oars and carrying 200 warriors. As the opposing fleets closed for battle, raining spears and arrows upon one another, he had smaller longships lashed to each side of his large warship, to provide a stable platform on which he and his followers could fight.

Earl Eirik led the attack on Olaf's floating fortress. Sailing alongside and grappling the smaller ships, Eirik's warriors boarded them and cleared their decks in tough hand-to-hand fighting. They then cut the hawsers holding the smaller ships to *Long Serpent*. Earl Eirik brought his longship *Barthi* directly alongside *Long Serpent*, but his first boarding party was repelled with heavy losses. Despite desperate resistance, Olaf's men were gradually worn down, until they held only the aft of their ship, grouped around their king. To avoid being taken, Olaf leaped into the sea and was never seen again. The victors divided Norway between them, with Earl Eirik taking the lion's share.



Presumed death of Olaf Trygvasson
The king throws himself overboard to avoid capture at Svold, an event that passed into Norse folklore.